APPENDIX A

LORE GLOSSARY

This appendix provides brief descriptions for many of the D&D game's most famous heroes, villains, creatures, locations, and materials. (If something isn't listed here, check the index to see whether it's covered elsewhere in the book.) The entries are presented in alphabetical order.

Terms in **bold** have their own entries in this appendix.

Acererak

Acererak *(ah-SAIR-er-rack)* is a powerful lich who travels between worlds and takes pleasure in devouring the souls of adventurers, whom he lures into trap-ridden dungeons to suffer horrible deaths. The most famous of such dungeons is the Tomb of Horrors, hidden in the Vast Swamp in the Greyhawk setting (see "Greyhawk Gazetteer" in chapter 5); another lies under the lost city of Omu in the jungles of Chult in the Forgotten Realms setting (described in the adventure *Tomb of Annihilation*).

Adamantine

Adamantine is one of the hardest substances in existence, a dark metal found in meteorites and extraordinary mineral veins. (See the *Adamantine Armor* and *Adamantine Weapon* magic items in chapter 7.)

Alustriel Silverhand

Alustriel *(ah-LOOSE-tree-ell)* Silverhand is the second of seven daughters of Mystra, a deity of magic in the Forgotten Realms setting. (**Laeral Silverhand** is Alustriel's younger sister.) She ruled the city of Silverymoon for centuries but stepped down from that position a little over a century ago to promote goodness and compassion in the multiverse. She has befriended adventurers such as **Drizzt Do'Urden** and worked alongside the **Harpers** in pursuit of these aims.

Ashardalon

The terrible red dragon Ashardalon *(ah-SHAR-duh-lawn)* is legendary across the multiverse for his rampages, which turned lush grasslands into ashen plains and caused mighty citadels to be swallowed into the earth. As he grew aware of worlds beyond his home, he recruited a balor demon named Ammet, the Eater of Souls, to help him extend his reach and increase his power. When an adventurer dealt a mortal blow to Ashardalon's heart, the dragon replaced the injured organ with the balor. Ashardalon's features then took on a fiendish cast, and his eyes now glow with demonic flame. A secretive cult of Ashardalon's followers and spawn serves him on the Material Plane, furthering the dragon's schemes to attain godhood.

Baba Yaga

Baba Yaga *(BAH-bah YAH-gah)* is an arch-hag known as the Mother of All Witches. She is also the adoptive mother of **Iggwilv**. Baba Yaga is famous for her chicken-legged hut, in which she travels across the planes of the multiverse. This impatient, foul-tempered hag is a font of knowledge about all things magical.

Bahamut

Bahamut *(ba-HA-mutt)* is one of the primordial dragons who (along with **Tiamat**) is said to have created the **First World**. For practical purposes, he is a god—ageless and immortal—who has dwelled in Mount Celestia (see chapter 6) since the destruction of the First World. In the Dragonlance setting, where he is called Paladine *(PAL-a-deen)*, he is the greatest of the gods of good. On other worlds, he is revered as a god of justice and nobility and is favored by Paladins.



Acererak

To metallic dragons, Bahamut is more like a king than a god. Individual dragons might owe Bahamut allegiance, respect him, pay tribute to him, and strive to emulate him, but they don't worship him.

Baldur's Gate

The city of Baldur's Gate *(BAWL-durz GATE)*, in the Forgotten Realms setting, is a teeming metropolis haunted by the lingering influence of three evil gods (Bane, Bhaal, and Myrkul) who refuse to stay dead. It's a place where a sword for hire can find a rich patron, join a secret guild, pursue killers for a bounty, or aid desperate citizens. The city offers opportunities for good-hearted champions to fight against corruption and bring murderers to justice, while less moral mercenaries find a good price for their services. Baldur's Gate hosts the most reliable and ruthless market on the **Sword Coast**. Information, treasures, secrets, and souls can be bought or sold for the right price.

Barovia

Barovia *(buh-ROVE-ee-ah)* is a Domain of Dread sequestered in the Shadowfell (see chapter 6)—a sort of spiritual prison for **Strahd von Zarovich** in his **Castle Ravenloft**. It's also the name of a village in that domain.

Bigby

Bigby *(BIG-bee)* is a former apprentice of **Mordenkainen**. Though he began his career determined to use magic to dominate and control others, Bigby eventually changed his ways and has worked hard to make amends for his past villainy. Mordenkainen welcomed Bigby into the adventuring company known as the Citadel of Eight (which later became the Circle of Eight, described in chapter 5). Shy and soft-spoken, Bigby was often eclipsed by his mentor, who taught Bigby how to control his ambitions. After years of adventuring, Bigby crafted a handful of spells that gained him widespread renown. Of these spells, *Bigby's Hand* is his undisputed magnum opus.

A recent misadventure led to Bigby's untimely demise. After he was crushed to death by a frost giant's boulder, Bigby was the target of a *Reincarnate* spell. The spell transformed Bigby from a human into a gnome. Before setting off on his next adventure, Bigby was overheard saying how curious he was to experience the multiverse from a gnome's perspective.

Boo

Boo is a hamster. More precisely, he is a miniature giant space hamster, a species native to Wildspace (see chapter 6) that is both sapient and telepathic. Boo's adventures with **Minsc**, as well as the hamster's ferocity, have given Boo legendary status, particularly in the city of **Baldur's Gate**.

Castle Ravenloft

Castle Ravenloft *(RAY-ven-loft)* is the heart of the domain of **Barovia** and the home of the vampire **Strahd von Zarovich**. *Ravenloft* is also one of the most famous dungeon adventures in the history of the D&D game, providing a horror-themed experience that inspired the creation of the Ravenloft setting and the adventure *Curse of Strahd*.

Companions of the Hall, The

Named for the dwarf stronghold of Mithral Hall in the Forgotten Realms setting, the Companions of the Hall is a group of heroic adventurers whose exploits have spanned centuries and even crossed the bounds of death. **Drizzt Do'Urden** is the central figure in this party; all his companions have died and been reincarnated in new forms in recent years. These other companions are Drizzt's wife, Cattie-Brie; his adoptive father, Bruenor Battlehammer; and his friends Wulfgar and Regis.

Company of Seven, The

The Company of Seven was a group of adventurers active hundreds of years ago in the Greyhawk setting. Its members included Heward, Keoghtom, Murlynd, Nolzur, Quaal, Tasha (see **Iggwilv**), and Zagig (see **Zagyg**). Some of these adventurers achieved near-divine status, and most of them are remembered for magic items that carry their names. The group inspired the formation of the Circle of Eight (described in the "Greyhawk" section in chapter 5).

Corellon

At the dawn of the multiverse, Corellon *(core-ELL-on or CORE-eh-lawn)* danced from world to world and plane to plane. A being of consummate mutability and infinite grace, Corellon is a whimsical shapeshifter, able to take the form of a chuckling stream, a teasing breeze, an incandescent beam, a school of fish, or a flock of birds. Corellon's flamboyant, mercurial personality infuses every form the god adopts. Corellon loves wholeheartedly and takes pleasure from every encounter with other divine beings of the multiverse.

According to legend, the first elves emerged from Corellon's shed blood, and they shared the god's changeable and audacious nature. Many elves, along with members of other species, worship Corellon.

Delina

Delina *(dell-EEN-ah)* is a young elf Sorcerer who wields the unpredictable power of wild magic. Finding herself in trouble in the city of **Baldur's Gate**, she accidentally reawakened the ancient hero of the city, **Minsc**, and got thrown into further adventures pursuing her lost twin brother.

Diancastra

Diancastra *(DIE-ann-CAST-rah)* is a demigod and a daughter of the divine ancestor of giants, Annam. She is a trickster, an adventurer, and a scholar of magic who enjoys wandering the Material Plane in search of new curiosities and spells to learn. She longs to see the descendants of Annam—storm, cloud, fire, frost, stone, and hill giants—restored to the position of honor and respect they held in ancient times.

Drizzt Do'Urden

Drizzt Do'Urden *(DRIZT doh-UR-den)* is a drow exile from the city of **Menzoberranzan** and a fugitive from the wrath of Lolth (see chapter 6) and her priests. He wandered the surface world and gathered a circle of friends who became known as the **Companions of the Hall**.

Elder Evils

The Elder Evils are a variety of entities whose existence dates to the beginnings of the multiverse—or possibly predates it. Some Elder Evils are creatures of the Far Realm (see chapter 6), while others are akin to gods or primordial beings of the Elemental Planes. Some are thought to be imprisoned, while others are said to be slumbering until they awaken in some apocalyptic cataclysm.

The names given to these terrible entities include such strange descriptions as Atropus, the World Born Dead; Dendar, the Night Serpent; **Hadar**, the Dark Hunger; Haemnathuun, the Blood Lord; Ityak-Ortheel, the Elf-Eater; Kezef, the Chaos Hound; **Kyuss**, the Worm That Walks; the Queen of Chaos; **Tharizdun**, the Chained God; Tyranthraxus, the Flamed One; and **Zargon**, the Returner. They are all forces of corruption and evil. Nothing good can come from their influence. Bargains made with them end in catastrophe or death.

Elminster

Elminster *(el-MIN-ster)* is a powerful and ancient archmage in the Forgotten Realms setting. As one of Mystra's Chosen, divinely called and empowered by the deity of magic, Elminster fosters magic and protects the fabric of magic in the world. Though this responsibility demands a certain amount of neutrality and dispassionate judgment, Elminster has a fundamentally kind and compassionate heart.

Euryale

One card in the *Deck of Many Things* (see chapter 7) bears a person's proper name, and the card's namesake, Euryale *(YUR-ee-ale or yur-EYE-a-lee)*, is the subject of much speculation. Often assumed to be a fearsome demigod (perhaps the first medusa) or the wielder of a destructive curse, Euryale is actually a key part of the story of the magical deck's creation. After befriending a princess named Asteria and spending many years in her dear friend's company, Euryale was captured and sentenced to death by Asteria's father. Asteria pleaded with the gods to save her friend, and Istus (a god from the Greyhawk setting; see chapter 5) intervened to help the pair rewrite their story, creating the *Deck of Many Things*. The magic of the deck helped the two escape, and they adventured together across the multiverse. Eventually, Euryale—having become an ancient, wise, and powerful Druid—settled in the Outlands (see chapter 6), where she still sometimes acts as a patron, mentor, or ally for adventurers.

Fallbacks, The

Tessalynde is a young elf Rogue who dreams of leading the foremost adventuring party of the Forgotten Realms setting. While the crew she's gathered isn't the stuff of legend yet, she's confident her guidance can get them there. Called the Fallbacks, the team includes Anson, a human Fighter too stubborn to stay down; Cazrin, a self-taught, human Wizard determined to test her theoretical mettle against the real world; Baldric, a dwarf Cleric who refuses to tie himself to a single deity when he can trade favors with them all; Lark, a tiefling Bard with as many secrets as songs; and Uggie, a pet otyugh.

First World, The

Scholars speak of a primordial state, a single reality they call the First World, which preceded the Material Plane. Many of the peoples and monsters that inhabit the worlds on the Material Plane originated there. After the First World was shattered by a great cataclysm—giving birth to the worlds that came in its wake—the progeny of the first elves, dwarves, beholders, and other iconic creatures took root on world after world, like seeds scattered by a cosmic wind. If the musings of these great sages are true, every world of the Material Plane is a reflection—or, in some cases, a distortion—of the First World.

Fizban

In the Dragonlance setting, **Bahamut**—who is known there as Paladine—dwelled among mortals in human guise for a time, aiding the forces of good against Takhisis (see **Tiamat**). He appeared as a bumbling old mage named Fizban *(FIZZ-ban)* the Fabulous.

Great Modron March, The

When the gears of the plane of Mechanus (see chapter 6) complete seventeen cycles—once every 289 years—the modron *(MOE-dron)* leader, Primus, sends a vast army of modrons across the Outer Planes. The purpose of this march is unclear. Most believe it to be a data-gathering mission meant to ascertain



The Great Modron March

the current state of the cosmos, but some see it as reconnaissance aimed at some future act of conquest. The march is long and dangerous, and only a small number of modrons returns to Mechanus.

Gruumsh

Gruumsh *(GROOMSH)* is a warring god who is often described as the creator or patron of the orc people. Some orcs attribute their tenacity and toughness to Gruumsh's lingering influence. Some myths describe a primeval conflict between Gruumsh and **Corellon**, which resulted in Gruumsh losing one eye and Corellon's spilled blood becoming the first elves.

Hadar

Hadar *(HAY-dar or ha-DARR)*, the Dark Hunger, is an ancient stellar entity originating from the Far Realm (see chapter 6). It appears as a cinder-red dying star, barely visible in the night sky, and it siphons life from its minions to avert its own demise. Two widely used Warlock spells invoke Hadar's power (see the *Arms of Hadar* and *Hunger of Hadar* spells in the *Player's Handbook*), and a few Warlocks claim this **Elder Evil** as their Great Old One patron.

Harpers, The

The Harpers is a scattered network of spellcasters and spies in the Forgotten Realms setting. Its members advocate equality and covertly oppose the abuse of power, magical or otherwise.

The Harpers has risen, been shattered, and risen again several times. The faction's longevity and resilience are largely due to its decentralized, grassroots, secretive nature and the autonomy of its members. It has small cells and lone operatives throughout the Forgotten Realms, although they interact and share information with one another as the need arises. The Harpers' ideology is noble, and members pride themselves on their ingenuity and incorruptibility. Harpers don't seek power or glory, only fair treatment for all.

Heroes of the Lance, The

The adventurers known as the Heroes of the Lance, whose deeds helped prevent Takhisis (see **Tiamat**) and her evil dragons from conquering the world of the Dragonlance setting, began as a small group of young adventurers and their aging dwarf mentor. This original group (known as the Innfellows) consisted of Tanis Half-Elven, the brothers Raistlin and Caramon Majere, Sturm Brightblade, a kender (similar to a halfling) named Tasslehoff Burrfoot, the dwarf Flint Fireforge, and Kitiara Uth Matar, Raistlin and Caramon's older half-sister. While Kitiara eventually joined Takhisis's service, the heroes were joined by others: Riverwind and Goldmoon, from the nomadic peoples of the plains; Gilthanas and Laurana, elf friends from Tanis's childhood; and Tika Waylan, a young barmaid whom the original Innfellows remembered as just a kid.

Heroes of the Realm, The

The so-called "heroes of the Realm" are a group of young adventurers—Bobby, Diana, Eric, Hank, Presto, and Sheila—who traveled from Earth in the 1980s into a world in the D&D multiverse. Equipped with powerful magic items, they foiled the schemes of foes such as **Venger** and **Tiamat** while seeking some means to return home. Eventually, as the heroes' mastery of adventuring skills increased, they discovered the secrets of traveling between worlds, though they still haven't found a way home.

The heroes of the Realm weren't the only kids transported from Earth to the worlds of D&D. Other young adventurers, including Niko the Cleric, are still exploring the vast D&D multiverse.

ZUZANNA WUZYK

Icewind Dale

Icewind Dale is the northernmost settled region of the Forgotten Realms setting. Freezing wind sweeps across the tundra, finding its way through every crack and draining any hint of warmth. Between the ice cliffs of the eastern glacier, the snowcapped peaks of the mountains to the south, and the Sea of Moving Ice to the north and west, ten small towns cluster around three icy lakes.

Iggwilv

Before she changed her name and conquered enough of Eastern Oerik (the Greyhawk setting) to rightfully call herself the Witch Queen of Perrenland, Iggwilv *(IGG-wilv)* was known as Tasha, a human mage who began her career as the apprentice of Zagig Yragerne (see **Zagyg**). Later, as an adventurer, she created several new spells, including *Tasha's Hideous Laughter* and *Tasha's Bubbling Cauldron*, leaning on the teachings of her adoptive mother, the arch-hag **Baba Yaga**. As Tasha grew in power and made powerful enemies, she changed her name to Iggwilv. In this guise, she became enchanted with the power of the Abyss and wrote the definitive treatise on demonkind: the *Demonomicon of Iggwilv* (see chapter 7). She also bound and trapped the demon lord Graz'zt (see chapter 6).

Iggwilv ruled Perrenland as a tyrant. When Graz'zt escaped his magical prison, Iggwilv went into hiding. Iggwilv's current location is unknown, but she left behind a cambion son (**Iuz**), who has his mother's tyrannical bent, and a daughter (Drelnza), who is now a vampire and lairs in the Lost Caverns of Tsojcanth (see "Greyhawk Gazetteer" in chapter 5), not far from her mother's old haunts.

Iuz

Iuz *(EYE-ooze or eye-OOZE)* is a cambion and the son of **Iggwilv** and Graz'zt (see chapter 6). He is every bit as evil as his father and as bent on conquest as his mother at her very worst. He rules a significant portion of Eastern Oerik (in the Greyhawk setting), and some fear that he aspires to conquer even more territory. See "Greyhawk's Premise" in chapter 5.

Jallarzi Sallavarian

The youngest and most recently appointed member of the Circle of Eight (see chapter 5), Jallarzi Sallavarian *(juh-LAR-zee sal-ah-VAIR-ee-en)* is a Warlock with a celestial patron. She is more inclined toward good than the more neutral members of the Circle of Eight and enjoys wandering the Free City of Greyhawk (see chapter 5) in disguise, monitoring sinister elements of society there.

Kas the Betrayer

Kas *(KOSS)* is a vampire, legendary swordfighter, and ruthless warlord. He once served as the leader of **Vecna**'s armies and the lich's most trusted lieutenant, and he wielded a sword made for him (the *Sword of Kas*, described in chapter 7) by his liege. But the evil sword convinced Kas to betray Vecna, and now Kas is driven primarily by his hatred for his former lord.

Keraptis

According to legend, Keraptis *(kuh-RAP-tiss)* was an evil archmage who long ago seized power as a petty tyrant somewhere in the northern mountains of the Greyhawk setting. When his demands on the local populace became too extreme, a revolt drove him into hiding. He disappeared into the tunnels beneath White Plume Mountain (see "Greyhawk's Premise" in chapter 5). It's conceivable that he became a lich as the grim climax of his magical research.



The wizard Tasha, before she became Iggwilv the Witch Queen



Kyuss

Variously identified as an **Elder Evil**, as a demigod, or as a mortal priest of the demon lord Orcus (see chapter 6), Kyuss *(KYE-uss)* is a mysterious figure best known as the Worm That Walks. Kyuss manifests on the Material Plane as a colossal mass of maggots and worms animated by a single evil will.

Laeral Silverhand

Laeral *(LAIR-ull)* Silverhand is the fifth of seven daughters of Mystra, a deity of magic in the Forgotten Realms setting. (**Alustriel Silverhand** is Laeral's older sister.) She is over 700 years old, and after a period of withdrawal from public life, she now serves as the Open Lord of **Waterdeep**—the only one of the twenty or so Lords of Waterdeep whose identity is publicly known. Though her power has waxed and waned depending on Mystra's involvement with the world and has declined significantly in recent years, Laeral remains one of the most formidable spellcasters in a world known for powerful spellcasters.

League of Malevolence, The

The League of Malevolence is an odious assemblage of villains united in one purpose: the accumulation of power. Its founding member, Kelek the Sorcerer, expects his confederates to work together for their mutual benefit, but he also encourages them to pursue their own evil schemes. Other members include the remorseless killer for hire Warduke, the assassin Zarak, and the evil Zargash, a servant of Orcus. Skylla, a Warlock whose power derives from a pact with **Baba Yaga**, maintains a tenuous alliance with the league but despises Kelek.

Lord Soth

Lord Soth is a death knight in the Dragonlance setting—a former Paladin who allowed his pride to lead him into evil. Offered an opportunity to redeem himself by averting a cataclysmic event, his pride again led him to abandon his quest and allow the devastation of his world. His mortal life ended in that cataclysm, but he rose from the ashes into undeath and retreated to his cursed castle, Dargaard Keep. He ignored the outside world for many centuries until the Dragon Queen Takhisis (see **Tiamat**) called him forth to serve her in the War of the Lance.

Menzoberranzan

The **Underdark** city of Menzoberranzan *(men-zoh-buh-RAN-zan)*, lying far beneath the **Sword Coast** region of the Forgotten Realms, is ruled by tyrannical priests of the Demon Queen of Spiders, Lolth (see chapter 6). Most of its people are drow, whose noble houses are locked in a constant struggle for Lolth's favor and the power that comes with it.

Minsc

Minsc *(MINSK)* is a heroic Ranger from the land of Rashemen in the Forgotten Realms setting. Known for his good cheer, his hearty optimism, and his pet miniature giant space hamster, **Boo**, Minsc is particularly adored in the city of **Baldur's Gate**.

Mithral

Mithral *(MITH-ral)* is a light, flexible metal that resembles silver but is much more durable. Its most common use is for crafting lightweight armor that provides excellent protection without bulk or burden (see the *Mithral Armor* magic item in chapter 7).

Moradin

Myths told on many worlds describe Moradin *(MORE-ah-din)* crafting all the peoples of the Material Plane in his great workshop in Mount Celestia (see chapter 6), causing them to spring to life from inert metal when he cooled the heated castings with his breath. These myths are the source of Moradin's appellation, "All-Father." Many peoples across the multiverse, including many dwarves, worship Moradin.

Mordenkainen

Mordenkainen *(mor-den-KIGH-nen or mor-den-KAY-nen)* is a human archmage who maintains a residence in the Free City of Greyhawk and

HEIDI C. BALZER

another hidden somewhere in the Yatil Mountains between Perrenland and Ket (see chapter 5). He is the founder and leader of the Circle of Eight, which he created to implement his philosophy of balance in the world. Among Mordenkainen's celebrated accomplishments are several name-branded spells, including ones that create extradimensional mansions, swords of spectral force, and phantom watchdogs (detailed in the *Player's Handbook*).

Mordenkainen has visited numerous worlds and planes of existence, making friends and fomenting rivalries on many of them. He maintains a close friendship with his former apprentice **Bigby** and the famous archmage **Elminster** of Shadowdale. Mordenkainen's greatest rival is **Iggwilv**, a former adventuring companion.

Neverwinter

Once known in the Forgotten Realms setting as the Jewel of the North, the city of Neverwinter was badly damaged when a nearby volcano erupted about fifty years ago. Now, its people work furiously to rebuild. Some of its outer walls still lie in ruins, and several of its neighborhoods remain abandoned.

Dagult Neverember is the Lord Protector of Neverwinter, ruling in the absence of a true heir to the crown. His dream is to see Neverwinter eclipse nearby **Waterdeep** in wealth and prosperity.

Otiluke

Otiluke *(AW-teh-luke)* is an impulsive, aggressive Wizard who is the main agent of the Circle of Eight in the Free City of Greyhawk (see chapter 5). He holds a position of political power and keeps his membership in the Circle of Eight secret. He is best known for his spells that create magical spheres (detailed in the *Player's Handbook*).

Otto

Otto *(AW-toe)* is an affable dwarf Bard with a taste for fine food, good music, and expensively tailored clothes. His sociable and outgoing personality masks the fact that he's also a member of the Circle of Eight (see chapter 5) and committed to the goals of that organization. He is well-known across the multiverse for his creation of the *Otto's Irresistible Dance* spell.

Phandalin

The frontier town of Phandalin *(FAN-duh-lin or fan-DAY-lin)* in the **Sword Coast** region of the Forgotten Realms setting is built on the ruins of a much older settlement. Hundreds of years ago, old Phandalin was a thriving town until it was sacked by bandits and lay abandoned for centuries.

In the past few years, hardy folk from the cities of **Neverwinter** and **Waterdeep** have begun settling atop the ruins of old Phandalin. It's now home to farmers, woodcutters, fur traders, and prospectors drawn by stories of gold and platinum in the foothills of the Sword Mountains—as well as more than a few ruffians and bandits.

Prince of Frost, The

The Prince of Frost is a son of Titania, the **Summer Queen**. He was once known as the Sun Prince, but his heart grew cold when he was spurned by the fey noble he loved. He is now a creature of wrath and winter, ruling from his Fortress of Frozen Tears in the Vale of Long Night in the Feywild (see chapter 6). He detests mortals of the Material Plane and dreams of covering their many worlds with perpetual winter.

Queen of Air and Darkness, The

The mysterious Queen of Air and Darkness is the archfey ruler of the Gloaming Court in the Feywild (see chapter 6). Though she is often described as malicious and evil, her motivations are as obscure and whimsical as any other archfey's. She gives supernatural boons and terrible curses with equal whimsy, with little regard for the elaborate customs surrounding gifts and favors in other courts of the Feywild. Though she is said to have a spectral form resembling a terrifying elf, to the unaided eye she appears as a strange, black diamond, hovering in the air like the slitted pupil of an unseen cat.



The Prince of Frost



The Raven Queen

Raven Queen, The

The Raven Queen is a being of mystery. Those who claim to have encountered her have described an array of disturbing images: a terrible shadow that clawed at their innermost thoughts, a pale and regal elf who exploded into an untold number of ravens, a shambling tangle of slick roots and sticks that overwhelmed them with dread, or an unknown presence that pulled them screaming into the gloom.

Despite all attempts to demystify her, the Raven Queen has remained enigmatic and aloof. She rules from her Raven Throne within the Fortress of Memories, a mazelike castle deep within the bleakness of the Shadowfell (see chapter 6). From there she sends out her raven servants to find interesting souls she can pluck from the planes of existence. Once these souls are in the Shadowfell, she watches as they attempt to unravel the mystery of their being.

Rock of Bral, The

Bral is a city built on an asteroid that drifts through Wildspace (see chapter 6). Its inhabitants, who hail from many worlds across the Material Plane, typically refer to Bral as the Rock. There is no other place quite like it in Wildspace—a teeming hive of business that spans the breadth of the Astral Sea.

Bral is populated by an outlandish collection of traders, scoundrels, mercenaries, pirates, nobles, and entrepreneurs. Generally, law enforcement is sporadic, which means that order is elusive. Most folks who call the Rock home adhere to two principles: mind your own business whenever possible, and enough gold can fix anything.

Rudolph van Richten

A scholar and monster hunter, Rudolph van Richten has traveled to dozens of Domains of Dread in the Shadowfell (see chapter 6), investigating reports of monstrous beings and documenting them in a series of published guides, the best known of which is *Van Richten's Guide to Vampires*.

In kinder days, Rudolph lived with his wife, Ingrid, and son, Erasmus, but he lost them both to a wicked vampire. In the process of hunting the vampire, Rudolph came under a terrible curse: "Live you always among monsters, and see everyone you love die beneath their claws."

In the decades since, van Richten has hunted monsters and armed others with the knowledge they need to confront evil. Though he's made many devoted allies, he keeps them at arm's length, fearing the threat of his curse.

Van Richten is closely associated with other heroes who prowl the Domains of Dread, including the detective Alanik Ray and his partner Arthur Sedgwick, the explorer Ez d'Avenir, and the twins Gennifer and Laurie Weathermay-Foxgrove.

Strahd von Zarovich

A brilliant thinker and capable warrior in life, Strahd von Zarovich *(STRAWD von zuh-ROH-vitch or ZAR-oh-vitch)* fought in countless battles for his people. After a long life of warfare and slaughter, he settled in the remote valley of **Barovia** and built a castle on a towering pinnacle. His brother Sergei came to live with him in **Castle Ravenloft**, becoming Strahd's adviser and constant companion.

In his brother, Strahd saw everything he was not. Resentment colored their relationship and eventually turned into hatred. Strahd's beloved, Tatyana, spurned Strahd for Sergei, whom she pledged to marry.

In a desperate attempt to regain Tatyana's love, Strahd forged a pact with dark powers that made him immortal. Strahd confronted his brother at Sergei and Tatyana's wedding and killed him. Tatyana fled and flung herself from Ravenloft's walls. Guards shot Strahd with arrows, but he didn't die. He became a vampire—the first vampire, according to many sages.

In the centuries since his transformation, Strahd's lust for life has grown. He broods in his castle, cursing the living for all he has lost and never admitting to his role in the tragedy.



The Summer Queen

Summer Queen, The

Titania, the Summer Queen, is the regal and charismatic ruler of the Summer Court in the Feywild (see chapter 6). Perhaps the mightiest of the archfey, she can ripen a crop with a smile and summon wildfires with the merest crinkling of her brow.

Sword Coast, The

The Sword Coast is the western edge of the continent of the Forgotten Realms setting, running along the Sea of Swords. It's a narrow band of territory dominated by several major city-states, from **Neverwinter** in the north to **Baldur's Gate** in the south, with **Waterdeep** in between.

Szass Tam

Szass Tam *(ZASS TAM)* is a powerful lich and necromancer in the Forgotten Realms setting. As leader of the Red Wizards of Thay, he has countless spies, assassins, and other agents at his service, and his schemes span centuries and reach to the ends of the world.

Tasha

See **Iggwilv**.

Tharizdun

For a being known as the Chained God, the **Elder Evil** Tharizdun *(thuh-RIZZ-dun or thair-izz-DOON)* has managed to extend his baleful influence from the Greyhawk setting through many worlds of the Material Plane. He is an ancient force of entropy, the end of all things and the extinction of life. His worshipers are nihilists who seek to end all worlds by liberating their god. Tharizdun is often linked to cults of Elemental Evil (see chapter 5).

Tiamat

Tiamat *(TEE-a-mat)* is one of the primordial dragons who (along with **Bahamut**) is said to have created the **First World**. Since the destruction of the First World, she has made her home in the Nine Hells (see chapter 6), where she is served by devils and enjoys the worship of mortals across the multiverse. In the Dragonlance setting, where she is known as Takhisis *(ta-KEE-sis)*, she is the greatest of the gods of evil. On many worlds, she is known as a god of greed, wealth, and vengeance.

Chromatic dragons might fear, respect, envy, and appease Tiamat as a sovereign, but they don't worship her. Their devotion to her rarely supersedes their devotion to their own goals.

Underdark, The

The Underdark is a vast subterranean realm of natural caverns and passages extending far beneath the surface of most D&D worlds. Many creatures inhabit the Underdark, including drow, duergar, svirfneblin, and other species that have adapted to the world below the surface.

Undermountain

Undermountain is the largest, deepest dungeon in the Forgotten Realms setting. It's a series of interconnected dungeon levels sprawling far beneath the city of **Waterdeep**. Its tunnels connect to preexisting **mithral** mines and natural caverns of the **Underdark**. The best-known entrance to Undermountain is through the **Yawning Portal** tavern in Waterdeep, but other routes also exist. A reclusive and cantankerous archmage named Halaster Blackcloak claims Undermountain as his domain, although his overlordship isn't widely acknowledged by the dungeon's other denizens.

Vajra Safahr

Vajra Safahr *(VAWJ-rah sah-FAR)* is a human Wizard in her midthirties, making her the youngest person ever to hold the position of Blackstaff—the chief mage of **Waterdeep** and the head of Blackstaff Academy, a school for mages. Several of the older and more seasoned mages of Waterdeep consider Vajra an upstart, but they are smart enough not to



Vecna

challenge her. As the badge of her office, she carries the *Blackstaff*, an Artifact that holds the spirits of all her predecessors.

Valor's Call

The noble adventuring party known as Valor's Call was founded by Strongheart, a resolute human Paladin committed to destroying evil wherever it rears its head. Strongheart alone determines who can become a member of this prestigious group, and he is always looking for courageous heroes willing to devote themselves to a good cause.

Only good-aligned characters can join Valor's Call. The group enjoys the patronage of **Yolande**, the queen of Celene, and carries out missions on her behalf both in the Greyhawk setting (see chapter 5) and in the Feywild (see chapter 6).

Prominent members of Valor's Call include the dwarf Fighter Elkhorn, the human Cleric Mercion, the human Rogue Molliver, and the human Wizard Ringlerun.

Vecna

Vecna *(VECK-nah)* had humble beginnings in the Greyhawk setting, where an order of Wizards used him as a bootblack and scribe. He studied magic in secret until he amassed enough power to slaughter the order, and then he turned his efforts toward scribing the *Book of Vile Darkness* (described in chapter 7). Armed with that dread tome, he forged a kingdom to rule, with the vampire **Kas** as his lieutenant. But Kas betrayed and killed him, leaving only one hand and one eye intact (the *Eye and Hand of Vecna* are described in chapter 7).

Vecna's evil will was so great that he persisted beyond death and eventually became a demigod of secrets and evil magic. His ambition drives him to pursue greater divine power across the multiverse.

Venger

Venger *(VEN-jur)* was once both human and good-hearted, but some fiendish force transformed him into a winged, one-horned villain. His schemes have spanned centuries and worlds, as he seeks to seize ever-increasing magical power. He has a particular loathing for **Tiamat** and longs to overthrow her. He is often seen astride a flying black steed, his shadowy adviser in tow.

Vi

Vi *(VYE)* is a gnome artificer, entrepreneur, and traveler of many worlds who originally hails from Eberron. After helping to create terribly destructive weapons during the Last War, Vi sought to atone for this guilt by establishing the Fixers, an organization dedicated to solving apparently hopeless problems. From the Fixers' headquarters in Sigil, Vi has brought her genius, warm heart, and love for a stiff drink to many worlds across the multiverse.

Vlaakith

Vlaakith *(VLAH-kith)* is the lich-queen of the githyanki city of Tu'narath, adrift in the Astral Plane (see chapter 6). She is ancient, having fought alongside a leader named Gith to win her people's freedom from the mind flayers that enslaved them. Githyanki of Tu'narath swear unquestioning obedience to the lich-queen, and she promises access to paradise to those who serve her loyally. In truth, she feasts on the souls of any subjects who grow powerful enough to dream of challenging her.

Waterdeep

Waterdeep is the most famous and cosmopolitan city in the Forgotten Realms setting. It's a center of wealth and influence where people come to make their dreams come true. The city is home to the **Yawning Portal**, the best-known point of access to the sprawling dungeon of **Undermountain**.

Xanathar

Xanathar *(ZAN-a-thar)* is an eccentric beholder crime lord dwelling beneath **Waterdeep**. Desiring to

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know all there is to know, Xanathar collects knowledge from across the multiverse, but its most prized possession is its goldfish, Sylgar.

Yawning Portal, The

The Yawning Portal is a tavern in **Waterdeep**, built around an entrance to the infamous dungeon of **Undermountain**. Adventurers throughout the Forgotten Realms setting and elsewhere in the multiverse visit the Yawning Portal to exchange knowledge about Undermountain and other dungeons. Most visitors are content to swap stories by the hearth, but some adventurers pay the toll for entry into Undermountain (collected by the mysterious owner and bartender, Durnan).

Yolande

Yolande *(yoh-LAWND)*, known as the Faerie Queen, is the benevolent and beloved elf monarch of Celene (see chapter 5). Raised in the court of the **Summer Queen**, Yolande had no wish to rule. She preferred the life of an adventuring magic-user. She built her reputation on triumphs, such as her capture of the fomorian brigand Solgna and the theft of the **Prince of Frost**'s sentient sword, *Winterflash*. Yolande was among the first elves to migrate from the Feywild to the Greyhawk setting.

Zagyg

The archmage Zagig Yragerne *(ZAG-igg EE-rag-airn)* was an adventurer in the Greyhawk setting and a member of the **Company of Seven.** At the climax of a long and prosperous adventuring career, he built a fortress known as Castle Greyhawk outside the Free City of Greyhawk (see chapter 5). From this stronghold, he took an increasingly powerful role in the politics of the city, contributing to its reputation as "the Gem of the Flanaess." He obsessively delved deeper under his castle and withdrew from the outside world until he managed to entrap nine demigods in magical prisons and claim a fragment of their divine power. He ascended to a minor form of godhood, took the name Zagyg, and took a place in the court of Boccob, a god of magic.

Zargon

Zargon *(ZAR-gawn)* is an **Elder Evil**—an undying abomination from eons past with an insatiable appetite. A tentacled, slime-covered horror with a cyclopic red eye and an indestructible horn, Zargon corrupts creatures it doesn't devour, transforming its victims into amorphous servants. Zargon is imprisoned on the Material Plane in a prison deep in the earth. This prison is described in the *Quests from the Infinite Staircase* adventure anthology.



XANATHAR IS A TYRANNICAL CRIME LORD AS WELL AS A BEHOLDER.